



OFF-SIDE

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INFANTINO MAY HAVE OVERPLAYED HIS HAND

UEFA, CONCACAF and the AFC have forced Gianni Infantino to withdraw his controversial plan to sell a minority stake in FIFA's commercial assets. But the **rebellion has exposed** something more consequential: the limits of the FIFA president's power.

FIFA president Gianni Infantino has been shown three red cards.

UEFA, CONCACAF and the Asian Football Confederation (AFC) have rejected FIFA's plan to sell a minority stake in a new commercial subsidiary housing virtually every revenue-generating asset the governing body owns. While UEFA threatened to boycott FIFA competitions, CONCACAF and the AFC called for the proposal to be abandoned.

Faced with opposition from three confederations representing 143 of FIFA's 211 member associations, Infantino eventually withdrew the proposal. But his retreat has done little to quell the rebellion.

In a joint letter, senior figures from UEFA, AFC and CONCACAF went beyond the abandoned commercial proposal and questioned Infantino's leadership.

"Leadership in football is not a possession," the letter said. "It is not about holding — or demanding — power to be held. It is a duty of service to the football family that entrusts it. When trust is broken through deception, when an individual places himself above the collective that entrusted him with authority, that duty has been abandoned."

It also rejected Infantino and FIFA's explanation that the project had merely become too divisive.

"It treats this as a failure of communication, when what football witnessed was a failure of judgment," the letter said, describing the attempt to sell an interest in the World Cup as "a fundamental breach of trust".

It is difficult to remember another moment in Infantino's presidency when such a broad coalition has confronted him. Since taking office in 2016, he has expanded FIFA's competitions and revenues and, critics would argue, his own authority. Opposition has generally been fragmented.

The proposed FIFA Football Enterprises (FFE) would have housed broadcasting rights, sponsorships, ticketing, hospitality and licensing before FIFA sold a minority stake to outside investors for fresh capital. FIFA insisted

investors would have no sporting authority and that it would retain majority control.

Yet the proposal asked football to accept something it has historically resisted: that the World Cup, perhaps the last truly universal sporting event, should also become an investment asset.

The politics surrounding it made matters worse. Infantino has drawn himself increasingly close to Donald Trump. FIFA opened an office inside Trump Tower in New York and presented the U.S. President with its inaugural Peace Prize. The proposed transaction was being led by Thrive Eternal, whose leadership includes members of Trump's extended family.

The demise of the unholy FFE has spilled over into a much larger battle.

England, Wales and Finland are among the associations that have withdrawn letters supporting Infantino's candidature for another term. But Argentina, Morocco, Mexico, Sri Lanka, Qatar and the African confederation have pledged their support, leaving the football world divided.

CONCACAF president Victor Montagliani is viewed as a potential challenger to Infantino, who is seeking a fourth and final term in FIFA's presidential election in Rabat next March. Candidates must declare by November 18.

For years, challenging Infantino appeared futile. His strength lay in relationships cultivated among FIFA's smaller associations through development funding and increased financial distributions. One country, one vote has served him well.

That constituency has not disappeared. But football politics depends as much on the perception of power as on power itself. An incumbent who appears unbeatable discourages challengers. An incumbent forced into retreat suddenly looks different.

The three red cards have not sent Infantino off. And it remains to be seen whether FIFA's 211 member associations have the appetite to wrest control of football from an administration whose claim to act in the game's collective interest has been seriously discredited.